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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

Political Science

International Organisations in a Unipolar World

Official Syllabus · Contemporary World Politics · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

INSIDE
Concept Notes

INSIDE
Solved Examples

INSIDE
Practice MCQs + Solutions

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
Restructuring of the UN	Restructuring and the future of the UN; Security Council expansion, reform criteria, and new bodies.	Tracing the evolution from League of Nations to UN (1945); evaluating Kofi Annan's 1997 reform criteria, P5 veto power, Peacebuilding Commission (2005), and UNHRC (2006).
India's Position in the UN	India's position in the restructured UN; candidature for permanent UNSC membership.	Justifying India's claim through population, democracy, economic size, and peacekeeping troops; identifying obstacles (China, Coffee Club).
Bretton Woods Institutions	Rise of new international actors: new international economic organisations (IMF and World Bank).	Analyzing quota-based weighted voting in the IMF, US veto power (16.5%+), structural adjustment conditionalities, and developmental loans of the World Bank.
WTO & IAEA	World Trade Organization and International Atomic Energy Agency.	Recalling WTO succession from GATT (1995), Geneva headquarters, TRIPS disputes, and IAEA's nuclear safeguards role (Vienna, 1957).
Global Civil Society & NGOs	Rise of NGOs: Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch.	Identifying the founding, mandates, and influence of Amnesty International (1961) and Human Rights Watch

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Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
		in spotlighting human rights violations.
Accountability in a Unipolar World	How democratic and accountable are the new institutions of global governance?	Evaluating US unipolar hegemony, funding dependencies, unilateralism in Iraq (2003), and the indispensability of the UN as a global forum.

CUET UG Exam Strategy — Chapter 4 Focus (World Politics)

- **Pattern:** 50 Multiple Choice Questions (attempt any 40) in 60 minutes.
- **Marking:** +5 marks for correct choice, −1 mark negative deduction for incorrect choice.
- **High-Yield Angles:** Date of UN founding (24 October 1945) and India's accession (30 October 1945), Kofi Annan's 1997 reform criteria, WTO founding date (1 January 1995), IAEA headquarters (Vienna), and non-permanent UNSC term limits (2 years).

1. Why Do We Need International Organisations?

International organisations are not world governments; they do not possess supreme authority over sovereign nation-states. Instead, they are indispensable instruments designed to facilitate peaceful interstate cooperation.

Core Functions of International Organisations

- **Conflict Prevention and De-escalation:** As former UN Secretary-General **Dag Hammarskjöld** famously declared: **"The United Nations was not created to take mankind to heaven, but to save humanity from hell."** International bodies provide institutional channels for negotiation, arbitration, and diplomacy to prevent minor disputes from spiraling into devastating wars.
- **Provision of Global Public Goods:** Vital international challenges—such as eradicating global pandemics (COVID-19, smallpox), combating global climate change, regulating international civil aviation, and coordinating space communication—cannot be resolved by any solitary nation, no matter how powerful. They require binding collective multilateral action.

2. Evolution and Organs of the United Nations

The United Nations was forged in the crucible of World War II to replace its discredited predecessor, the **League of Nations** (formed in 1919 under the Treaty of Versailles), which had failed to prevent the rise of fascism and the outbreak of the Second World War.

Chronology of the UN's Founding

- **Atlantic Charter (August 1941):** Signed by US President Franklin D. Roosevelt and British Prime Minister Winston Churchill on a warship in the Atlantic, outlining principles for post-war international peace.
- **Declaration by United Nations (January 1942):** 26 Allied nations fighting the Axis powers adopted the term "United Nations" coined by Roosevelt.
- **Yalta Conference (February 1945):** Churchill, Roosevelt, and Stalin ("The Big Three") agreed on the voting formula and the establishment of a post-war security body.
- **San Francisco Conference (April–June 1945):** Delegates from 50 nations drafted and signed the **Charter of the United Nations** on **26 June 1945**. (Poland signed later on 15 October 1945 as the 51st original founding member).
- **Official Inception (24 October 1945):** The UN officially came into legal existence when the Charter was ratified by the five permanent members and a majority of signatories. **24 October** is celebrated worldwide as **United Nations Day**.
- **India's Historic Accession:** India signed the UN Charter on **30 October 1945**, joining as an original founding member state.
- **Current Membership:** 193 sovereign nation-states. **South Sudan** joined as the 193rd member state in July 2011.

The Six Principal Organs of the UN

- **1. General Assembly (UNGA):**
  - The chief deliberative, policymaking, and representative organ comprising all 193 member states.
  - Operates on the democratic principle of **"one nation, one vote"**.
  - Decides critical questions (budget, admission of new members) by a two-thirds majority; ordinary resolutions are passed by simple majority (non-binding on member states).
- **2. Security Council (UNSC):**
  - Entrusted with the primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security.
  - Comprises **15 members**: **5 Permanent Members (P5)**—United States, United Kingdom, France, Russia, and China—and **10 Non-Permanent Members** elected by the General Assembly for staggered **two-year terms**.
  - **The Veto Power:** Under Article 27 of the Charter, any negative vote cast by any of the P5 members blocks the adoption of any non-procedural resolution, even if supported by all other 14 members.
- **3. Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC):**

- Comprises 54 member states elected for three-year terms to coordinate global economic, social, cultural, educational, and health work through specialized agencies (WHO, UNESCO, ILO, UNICEF).

- **4. Trusteeship Council:**
  - Established to supervise trust territories emerging from colonial rule. **Suspended operations on 1 November 1994** following the independence of Palau, the last remaining UN trust territory.
- **5. International Court of Justice (ICJ):**
  - The principal judicial organ of the UN, permanently headquartered at the Peace Palace in **The Hague (Netherlands)**.
  - Consists of **15 judges elected for 9-year terms** by simultaneous votes in the General Assembly and Security Council.
- **6. Secretariat:**
  - Headed by the **Secretary-General**, appointed by the General Assembly upon the recommendation of the Security Council for a renewable five-year term.
  - Current Secretary-General: **António Guterres** of Portugal (took office on 1 January 2017).

Secretary-General	Nationality / Term	Key Historical Milestone
Trygve Lie	Norway (1946–1952)	First UN Secretary-General; resigned over Soviet boycott during the Korean War.
Dag Hammarskjöld	Sweden (1953–1961)	Pioneered UN Peacekeeping; died tragically in a plane crash in the Congo in 1961; posthumous Nobel Peace Prize.
U Thant	Burma / Myanmar (1961–1971)	First non-European Secretary-General; mediated during the 1962 Cuban Missile Crisis.
Kofi Annan	Ghana (1997–2006)	Launched the Global Compact, Millennium Development Goals (MDGs), and 1997 UN reform blueprint; Nobel Peace Prize (2001).
Ban Ki-moon	South Korea (2007–2016)	Spearheaded the 2030 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and the landmark 2015 Paris Climate Agreement.
António Guterres	Portugal (2017–Present)	Former Prime Minister of Portugal and UN High Commissioner for Refugees; focuses on climate crisis and reform.

3. Reform of the United Nations: Structure and Jurisdiction

With the end of the Cold War, the disintegration of the Soviet Union, and the rise of developing powerhouses, demands for fundamental restructuring of the UN gained irresistible momentum.

Two Broad Categories of Reform

1. **Reform of Structures and Processes:** Democratizing the composition and decision-making procedures of the UN Security Council to reflect contemporary 21st-century geopolitical realities rather than the 1945 post-war order.
2. **Review of Jurisdictional Issues:** Clarifying the scope of UN interventions in domestic crises, human rights emergencies, and state sovereignty.

Kofi Annan's Six Criteria for New Permanent Members (1997)

In 1997, Secretary-General Kofi Annan proposed that any candidate nation aspiring to permanent membership in an expanded Security Council should fulfill the following six criteria:

- **1.** A major economic power.
- **2.** A major military power.
- **3.** A substantial contributor to the regular United Nations operating budget.
- **4.** A populous nation, reflecting a substantial segment of global humanity.
- **5.** A nation that respects democracy and fundamental human rights.
- **6.** A nation whose inclusion would make the Council representative of global diversity (geographical, economic, and cultural).

60th Anniversary World Summit Decisions (September 2005)

At the 2005 World Summit in New York, world leaders resolved to revitalize the UN through four landmark structural additions:

- **Establishment of the Peacebuilding Commission:** To assist countries emerging from civil war in post-conflict reconstruction and institutional stabilization.
- **Creation of the Human Rights Council (UNHRC):** Replaced the discredited, politicized UN Commission on Human Rights on **15 March 2006** as a standing subsidiary body of the General Assembly.
- **Endorsement of Responsibility to Protect (R2P):** Recognized the collective international obligation to intervene when sovereign states fail to protect their own populations from genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing, and crimes against humanity.
- **Creation of the UN Democracy Fund (UNDEF):** To finance grassroots democratic institutions and civil society organizations worldwide.

4. India's Claim for a Permanent Seat on the UN Security Council

India has consistently advocated for comprehensive expansion and restructuring of the Security Council in both the permanent and non-permanent categories.

Arguments Justifying India's Permanent Membership

- **Demographic Primacy:** India is the world's most populous nation, housing over 1.4 billion people (approximately one-sixth of all human beings on the planet).
- **Democratic Credentials:** India is the world's largest functioning democracy, maintaining an unbroken constitutional tradition of multi-party elections, rule of law, and civil liberties.

- **Economic Stature:** India is the world's fifth-largest economy by nominal GDP and the third-largest by Purchasing Power Parity (PPP), functioning as a primary engine of global economic expansion.
- **Peacekeeping Track Record:** India has been one of the largest and most consistent cumulative troop and police contributors to United Nations Peacekeeping Operations (UNPKOs), participating in over 50 missions and losing more peacekeepers in the line of duty than any other nation.
- **Non-Proliferation Responsibility:** Despite being a declared nuclear weapons state outside the NPT, India maintains an impeccable voluntary export-control record and an established doctrine of "No First Use".

Coalitions and Geopolitical Hurdles

- **The G4 Coalition:** India coordinates its diplomatic campaign alongside **Brazil, Germany, and Japan** (the **Group of Four or G4**), supporting each other's bids for permanent seats.
- **Opposition from Rivals:**
  - **China:** Remains the primary roadblock among the P5, using diplomatic stalling tactics and resisting Indian elevation without conditions.
  - **The "Coffee Club" (Uniting for Consensus):** An opposition coalition led by regional rivals (such as Pakistan opposing India, Italy opposing Germany, Argentina opposing Brazil, and South Korea opposing Japan) that advocates expanding non-permanent seats rather than permanent membership.
- **The Veto Standoff:** African and developing nations insist that any new permanent members must possess the identical veto power enjoyed by the P5; however, existing permanent members refuse to dilute their exclusive veto privileges.

5. New International Economic Organisations

The architecture of global economic governance is dominated by powerful multilateral and plurilateral institutions established in the aftermath of the Great Depression and World War II.

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) and World Bank (1944)

- **Bretton Woods Conference (1944):** Established the IMF and World Bank in New Hampshire (USA) to stabilize the international financial order.
- **International Monetary Fund (IMF):**
  - Oversees the global financial and monetary system, providing emergency balance-of-payments credit to debt-distressed nations.
  - **Weighted Voting:** Voting power is not equal; it is determined by the financial quota contributed by each member state. The **United States holds 16.5% of the total voting share**, giving it a unilateral veto over major structural decisions that require an 85% supermajority.
  - The combined G7 advanced economies control over 40% of the voting power, creating a severe democratic deficit for developing nations.

- Lends funds under strict **"structural adjustment"** conditionalities, forcing developing borrowers to slash social subsidies, privatize public assets, and open domestic markets to foreign capital.

- **The World Bank (IBRD & IDA):**
  - Finances infrastructure, health, education, and anti-poverty projects in low- and middle-income countries.
  - By historic unwritten diplomatic convention, the President of the World Bank is always an American citizen nominated by the US President, while the Managing Director of the IMF is always a European.

The World Trade Organization (WTO)

- **Successor to GATT:** Formally established on **1 January 1995** following the Marrakesh Agreement, succeeding the **General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT, 1948)**. Headquartered in **Geneva, Switzerland**, it encompasses 164 member states.
- **Mandate:** Sets the rules for international merchandise, services, and intellectual property trade (**TRIPS**), acting as an international dispute settlement mechanism.
- **Power Asymmetry:** Although decisions are formally taken by consensus (with each country possessing one vote), wealthy industrialized nations manipulate negotiations through informal "Green Room" conclaves, pressuring developing countries to lower tariffs while protecting their own domestic agricultural subsidies.

International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA, 1957)

- Established in **1957** in **Vienna, Austria**, following US President Dwight Eisenhower's historic **"Atoms for Peace"** speech to the UN General Assembly in 1953.
- **Dual Mandate:** Promotes the peaceful utilization of nuclear technology for electricity generation, medicine, and agriculture, while conducting rigorous on-site inspections (**safeguards**) of civilian nuclear reactors to ensure that fissile material is not diverted to nuclear weapons programs.

6. Non-Governmental Organisations (NGOs) & Global Civil Society

Non-state actors and international non-governmental organisations have emerged as powerful watchdogs, mobilizing global public opinion and holding national governments accountable to universal human rights standards.

Prominent Global Human Rights NGOs

- **Amnesty International:**
  - Founded in London in **1961** by British lawyer Peter Benenson.
  - Focuses on researching and campaigning against human rights abuses, advocating for the release of **prisoners of conscience**, and campaigning for the unconditional global abolition of the death penalty and torture.
  - Awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1977.
- **Human Rights Watch (HRW):**

- Established in 1978 (originally as Helsinki Watch) to monitor Soviet compliance with human rights accords.
- Conducts rigorous on-the-ground investigations into wartime atrocities, discrimination against minorities, child soldier recruitment, and government repression, lobbying international media and the UN to sanction offending regimes.

7. Global Governance in a Unipolar World

How democratic and effective are international institutions in an era dominated by United States military and economic preponderance?

Structural Hegemony of the United States

- **Physical and Financial Dominance:** The UN Headquarters is physically located on US sovereign soil in **New York City**, and the United States remains the single largest financial contributor to the regular UN budget (paying roughly 22%).
- **Unilateral Military Action:** When the UN Security Council refused to authorize the invasion of Iraq in 2003, the United States simply bypassed the UN, forming an ad-hoc "Coalition of the Willing" and launching military strikes without international legal sanction.
- **Veto Immunity:** The US veto prevents the Security Council from censuring Washington or its key geopolitical allies.

Why the UN Remains Indispensable

- Despite its structural shortcomings and vulnerability to superpower pressure, the United Nations remains the **only universal international arena** where all 193 sovereign nations meet to negotiate, debate, and resolve cross-border crises.
- It provides a vital platform for the nations of the Global South to challenge great-power hegemony, legitimize decolonization, and coordinate humanitarian aid to millions of vulnerable citizens worldwide.

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The Whole Chapter in One Picture



Figure 1: International Organisations Mindmap: Evolution of the UN, Kofi Annan's reform criteria, India's UNSC claim, IMF/World Bank weighted voting, WTO, IAEA, and global NGOs.



Figure 2: UN Architecture & Restructuring Matrix: UNSC expansion criteria, India's permanent seat justification, chronology of global bodies, and key exam pitfalls.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. On which date did the United Nations officially come into legal existence following the ratification of the Charter by the permanent members?

(A) 26 June 1945
(B) 24 October 1945
(C) 30 October 1945
(D) 10 December 1948

Q2. On which date did India formally sign the United Nations Charter, becoming an original founding member state of the world body?

(A) 15 August 1947
(B) 24 October 1945
(C) 30 October 1945
(D) 26 January 1950

Q3. Which country joined as the 193rd sovereign member state of the United Nations General Assembly in July 2011?

(A) Montenegro
(B) East Timor
(C) South Sudan
(D) Switzerland

Q4. The non-permanent members of the United Nations Security Council are elected by the General Assembly for a term of how many years?

(A) 1 year **(B)** 2 years
(C) 3 years **(D)** 5 years

Q5. Which principal organ of the United Nations suspended its formal operations on 1 November 1994 with the independence of Palau?

(A) Economic and Social Council **(B)** Trusteeship Council
(C) International Court of Justice **(D)** Human Rights Council

Q6. The International Court of Justice (ICJ), comprising 15 judges elected for 9-year terms, is permanently headquartered in which city?

(A) Geneva, Switzerland **(B)** New York, USA
(C) The Hague, Netherlands **(D)** Vienna, Austria

Q7. Which UN Secretary-General died tragically in a plane crash in the Congo in 1961 and was posthumously awarded the Nobel Peace Prize?

(A) Trygve Lie **(B)** Dag Hammarskjöld
(C) U Thant **(D)** Kurt Waldheim

Q8. The World Trade Organization (WTO) officially succeeded the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) on which date?

(A) 24 October 1945 **(B)** 1 January 1991
(C) 1 January 1995 **(D)** 11 December 2001

Q9. The International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), established under Dwight Eisenhower's 'Atoms for Peace' initiative in 1957, is headquartered in:

(A) Geneva **(B)** Paris
(C) Vienna **(D)** London

Q10. The international coalition formed by regional rivals (such as Pakistan, Italy, Argentina) to oppose the G4 bid for permanent UNSC seats is known as:

(A) The Non-Aligned Movement **(B)** Uniting for Consensus (Coffee Club)
(C) The Global South Coalition **(D)** The Cairns Group

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. The United Nations officially came into existence on 24 October 1945, which is celebrated internationally as United Nations Day.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. India signed the UN Charter on 30 October 1945 in San Francisco, becoming an original founding member state of the United Nations.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q3. South Sudan was admitted as the 193rd sovereign member state of the United Nations in July 2011 following its peaceful independence referendum from Sudan.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q4. Under Article 23 of the UN Charter, the 10 non-permanent members of the Security Council are elected for staggered 2-year terms and cannot be immediately re-elected.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q5. The Trusteeship Council suspended its formal operations on 1 November 1994 following the independence of Palau, the last remaining trust territory.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q6. The International Court of Justice (ICJ) is the only principal organ of the UN located outside New York; it is permanently seated at the Peace Palace in The Hague, Netherlands.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. Dag Hammarskjöld of Sweden, the second UN Secretary-General, was killed in a suspicious plane crash in Northern Rhodesia (now Zambia) in September 1961 during the Congo peace mission.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. The WTO was formally established on 1 January 1995 following the 1994 Marrakesh Agreement, taking over the mandate of the provisional GATT framework.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q9. The IAEA was established in 1957 and is permanently headquartered at the Vienna International Centre in Vienna, Austria, to inspect civilian nuclear programs.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q10. The 'Uniting for Consensus' group (popularly nicknamed the 'Coffee Club'), led by Italy, Pakistan, Mexico, and Argentina, opposes the expansion of permanent UNSC seats for the G4 nations.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q1 option A	Confusing signing date with entry into force	Charter was signed on 26 June 1945; UN officially came into existence on 24 October 1945.
Q2 option B	Using UN Day for India's accession	UN Day is 24 October; India officially signed the Charter 6 days later on 30 October 1945.
Q5 option D	Confusing Trusteeship Council with Human Rights	The Trusteeship Council suspended operations in 1994; the Human Rights Council was newly created in 2006.
Q8 option D	Using China's WTO entry date for WTO founding	WTO was founded on 1 January 1995; China gained accession to it in December 2001.
Q9 option A	Placing IAEA in Geneva	WTO and WHO are in Geneva; IAEA is headquartered in Vienna, Austria.

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